

Word family: **thin / thinner / thinnest / thinly / thinness / thin out**

Base word: thin

Comparative: thinner

Superlative: thinnest

Part of speech: mainly **adjective**, also **verb** and **adverb** in some uses

Related forms:

* **thin** (adj.) — 薄的；瘦的；稀薄的；稀疏的；淡的

* **thin** (v.) — 使變薄；使變稀；減少

* **thinly** (adv.) — 薄薄地；稀疏地

* **thinness** (n.) — 薄；瘦；稀薄

* **thin out** — 變稀疏；逐漸減少

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **thin person**

* **thin face**

* **thin layer**

* **thin paper**

* **thin ice**

* **thin air**

* **thin soup**

* **thin hair**

* **thin crowd**

* **thin voice**

* **thin excuse**

* **thin evidence**

* **spread something thinly**

* **thin out**

* **on thin ice**

* **vanish into thin air**

Meaning in this passage

> He was quite tall and **thin**.

Here, **thin** means:

having little body fat; not broad or heavy — 瘦的；身形纖瘦的

中文翻譯：

他身形頗高，也偏**瘦**。

So here:

thin = 身形瘦削、脂肪較少的

1. **thin (人：瘦的) — 瘦的；纖瘦的**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He was quite tall and **thin**.

他身形頗高，也偏**瘦**。

Practice 2

> He is naturally **thin**.

他天生比較**瘦**。

Practice 3

> She looked **thin** after being ill.

她病後看起來有點**消瘦**。

MCQ-ready definition:

thin = 身體脂肪較少、身形不厚重的

2. **thin face / arms / legs — 瘦削的臉 / 手臂 / 腿**

Practice 1

> He had a long, **thin face**.

他有一張修長而**瘦削的臉**。

Practice 2

> Her arms looked unusually **thin**.

她的手臂看起來異常**纖瘦**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****thin + body part = 某身體部位較窄、脂肪或肌肉較少****

3. ****thin (物件：薄的) — 薄的****

A major literal sense.

Practice 1

> The book is printed on very ****thin paper****.

這本書用很****薄的紙****印刷。

Practice 2

> She wore a ****thin jacket****.

她穿了一件很****薄的外套****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****thin = 從一面到另一面的厚度很小****

4. ****thin layer / slice — 薄層；薄片****

Practice 1

> Spread a ****thin layer**** of butter on the bread.

在麵包上塗一層****薄薄的牛油****。

Practice 2

> Cut the cucumber into ****thin slices****.

把青瓜切成****薄片****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****thin layer/slice = 厚度很小的一層或一片****

5. **thin ice** — 薄冰

Practice 1

> Be careful—the ice is very **thin**.

小心，冰層很**薄**。

Practice 2

> The lake was covered with a **thin layer of ice**.

湖面覆蓋着一層**薄冰**。

MCQ-ready definition:

thin ice = 厚度很小、容易破裂的冰層

6. **thin air** — 稀薄的空氣

Practice 1

> Breathing becomes harder in **thin air**.

在**稀薄空氣**中呼吸會較困難。

Practice 2

> At high altitude, the air is **thinner**.

在高海拔地區，空氣更**稀薄**。

MCQ-ready definition:

thin air = 密度較低、含氧量較少的空氣

7. **thin soup / sauce** — 稀的湯 / 醬汁

Practice 1

> The soup was too **thin**.

這湯太**稀**了。

Practice 2

> Add less water if the sauce becomes too **thin**.

如果醬汁太**稀**，就少加一點水。

MCQ-ready definition:

thin liquid = 濃度低、水分較多、不濃稠的液體

8. **thin hair — 稀疏的頭髮**

Practice 1

> His hair is getting **thin**.

他的頭髮開始變得**稀疏**。

Practice 2

> She has very **thin hair**.

她的頭髮很**稀少 / 幼細**。

MCQ-ready definition:

thin hair = 頭髮數量少、密度低，或髮絲較幼細

9. **thin crowd / attendance — 人少；稀疏**

Practice 1

> The crowd was surprisingly **thin**.

人群出奇地**稀疏**。

Practice 2

> Attendance was **thin** because of the bad weather.

因為天氣差，出席人數很**少**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****thin = 數量少、分布不密集****

10. ****thin vegetation / population — 稀疏的植被 / 人口****

Practice 1

> The area has ****thin vegetation****.

該地區植被很****稀疏****。

Practice 2

> The population is ****thinly spread**** across the region.

人口在該區域****分布得很稀疏****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****thin = 分布密度低、不集中****

11. ****thin voice / sound — 薄弱、尖細的聲音****

A figurative/perceptual extension.

Practice 1

> His voice sounded ****thin**** over the phone.

他的聲音透過電話聽起來很****單薄****。

Practice 2

> The recording had a ****thin sound****.

這段錄音的聲音聽起來很****薄弱、不飽滿****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****thin voice/sound = 聲音不厚實、不飽滿，常帶尖細或缺乏深度的感覺****

12. ****thin smile — 淡淡的 / 勉強的笑****

Practice 1

> She gave him a **thin smile**.

她對他露出一個**淡淡的 / 有點勉強的笑容**。

Practice 2

> A **thin smile** appeared on his face.

他臉上浮現一絲**淡淡的笑容**。

MCQ-ready definition:

thin smile = 幅度很小、感情不強或略顯勉強的笑

13. **thin excuse** — 站不住腳的藉口

A figurative sense.

Practice 1

> That's a pretty **thin excuse**.

那是一個很**牽強的藉口**。

Practice 2

> His explanation sounded **thin**.

他的解釋聽起來很**薄弱、站不住腳**。

MCQ-ready definition:

thin excuse/explanation = 理據不足、不太可信或說服力很弱的藉口 / 解釋

14. **thin evidence / support** — 薄弱的證據 / 支持

Practice 1

> The case is based on **thin evidence**.

這宗案件建立在**薄弱的證據**之上。

Practice 2

> There is only **thin support** for the claim.

這個說法只有很**有限 / 薄弱的支持**。

MCQ-ready definition:

thin evidence/support = 數量少、力度弱，不足以有力支持某個結論

15. **thinly** (薄薄地) — 薄薄地

Practice 1

> Slice the bread **thinly**.

把麵包**切薄一點**。

Practice 2

> Spread the paint **thinly**.

把油漆**薄薄地塗開**。

MCQ-ready definition:

thinly = 以很小的厚度

16. **thinly populated / spread** — 人口稀少 / 分布稀疏

Practice 1

> The region is **thinly populated**.

這個地區**人口稀少**。

Practice 2

> The houses are **thinly spread** across the valley.

房屋在山谷中**分布稀疏**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****thinly = 以低密度、相隔較遠的方式****

17. ****thin something — 使變薄 / 變稀****

As a verb.

Practice 1

> You can ****thin the sauce**** with a little water.

你可以加一點水把醬汁****調稀****。

Practice 2

> The gardener ****thinned the plants****.

園丁把植物****疏開 / 間苗****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****thin something = 令某物變得更薄、更稀或密度更低****

18. ****thin out — 逐漸變少 / 變稀疏****

Practice 1

> The crowd began to ****thin out**** after midnight.

午夜後，人群開始****逐漸散去、變少****。

Practice 2

> His hair is beginning to ****thin out****.

他的頭髮開始****變得稀疏****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****thin out = 數量或密度逐漸減少****

19. ****on thin ice — 處境危險；如履薄冰****

A very common idiom.

Practice 1

> You're **on thin ice** after missing another deadline.

你又一次錯過死線，現在可說是**如履薄冰**。

Practice 2

> He knew he was **on thin ice** with his manager.

他知道自己在經理面前已經**處境很危險**。

MCQ-ready definition:

be on thin ice = 處於容易惹麻煩、失去信任或受到懲罰的危險情況

20. **vanish/disappear into thin air** — **憑空消失**

Practice 1

> The keys seemed to **vanish into thin air**.

鎖匙好像**憑空消失**了。

Practice 2

> The money didn't just **disappear into thin air**.

那些錢不可能就這樣**憑空消失**。

MCQ-ready definition:

vanish/disappear into thin air = 突然完全消失，彷彿沒有留下任何痕跡

Important distinction 1: **thin vs slim**

Very important for describing people.

thin

neutral or sometimes slightly negative:

= not much body fat.

slim

usually more positive:
= attractively thin.

> He is **thin**.

他很瘦。

> She has a **slim figure**.

她身材苗條。

So **slim** often carries a more flattering tone.

Important distinction 2: **thin vs skinny**

skinny

more informal and often negative:
= very thin, sometimes too thin.

thin

more neutral.

> a thin man

一個瘦削的男人

> a skinny man

一個瘦得皮包骨 / 很瘦的男人

Important distinction 3: **thin vs lean**

lean

often means thin but strong/healthy, especially with little fat.

thin

does not imply muscularity.

> a lean athlete

精瘦的運動員

> a thin man

瘦削的男人

Important distinction 4: **thin vs narrow**

thin

small thickness.

narrow

small width.

> a thin book

薄書

> a narrow road

窄路

A sheet of paper can be thin but very wide.

Important distinction 5: **thin vs fine**

thin

small thickness.

fine

can mean very thin/delicate, especially fibres, lines, hair, particles.

> thin hair

頭髮稀疏 / 髮絲幼

> fine hair

幼細的頭髮

These can overlap but are not identical.

Important distinction 6: **thin hair = sparse vs fine**

This phrase can be ambiguous.

thin hair

may mean:

- * not much hair
- * hair becoming sparse
- * sometimes very fine strands

fine hair

specifically:

- * individual strands are narrow

So density and strand thickness should be distinguished.

Important distinction 7: **thin liquid vs watery**

thin

not thick/viscous.

watery

contains too much water and often sounds negative.

> a thin sauce

稀醬汁

> a watery soup

水汪汪、太稀的湯

Important distinction 8: **thin crowd vs small crowd**

small crowd

few people overall.

thin crowd

emphasizes low density / sparse presence.

They are close, but **thin** paints a more spatial picture.

Important distinction 9: **thin evidence vs little evidence**

little evidence

small quantity.

thin evidence

weak and insufficient.

So **thin** adds the idea of poor strength/quality, not only quantity.

Important distinction 10: **thin voice vs quiet voice**

thin voice

lacks fullness/depth.

quiet voice

low volume.

A voice can be thin but loud, or full but quiet.

Important distinction 11: **thin smile** vs **small smile**

small smile

simply slight in size.

thin smile

often suggests:

- * restrained emotion
- * lack of warmth
- * tension
- * insincerity

So **thin smile** carries more emotional nuance.

Important distinction 12: **thin as adjective** vs **thin as verb**

Adjective

> thin soup

稀的湯

Verb

> thin the soup

把湯調稀

Same semantic core, different grammatical function.

Family-extension note

Thin has a strong literal core:

having little thickness, density, or quantity

From that, several branches develop:

1. **body build**

* thin person

2. **physical thickness**

* thin paper

* thin layer

3. **density**

* thin air

* thin hair

* thin crowd

4. **consistency**

* thin soup

5. **sound / expression**

* thin voice

* thin smile

6. **figurative weakness**

* thin excuse

* thin evidence

7. **verb**

* thin the sauce

* thin out

The underlying metaphor is quite consistent: **less substance / less density / less strength**.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
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thin person	瘦的	little body fat
thin face	瘦削的臉	narrow/lean appearance

thin paper	薄紙	little thickness	
thin layer	薄層	small thickness	
thin ice	薄冰	fragile thin layer	
thin air	稀薄空氣	low density	
thin soup	稀湯	low thickness/viscosity	
thin hair	稀疏 / 幼細頭髮	low density/fineness	
thin crowd	稀疏人群	low density	
thin voice	單薄的聲音	lacks fullness	
thin smile	淡淡 / 勉強的笑	weak/restrained expression	
thin excuse	牽強藉口	weak justification	
thin evidence	薄弱證據	weak support	
thinly	薄薄地 / 稀疏地	low thickness/density	
thin something	使變稀 / 變薄	reduce density	
thin out	逐漸變少 / 稀疏	decrease density	
on thin ice	如履薄冰	risky situation	
vanish into thin air	憑空消失	disappear completely	

For your original sentence

> He was quite tall and **thin**.

Here:

thin = 身形偏瘦；脂肪較少的

The tone is mainly descriptive, not necessarily negative.

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他身形頗高，也偏**瘦**。

So the exact passage sense is the straightforward **body-build** meaning of **thin**.